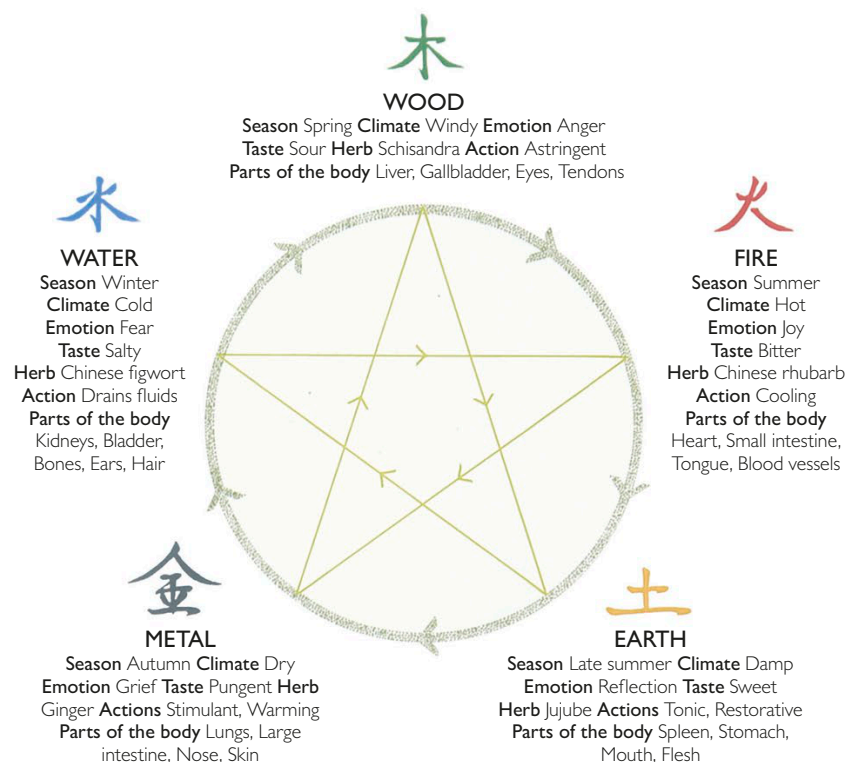




The ancient five elements theory is used by the Chinese when writing prescriptions. It associates herbs with the natural world, including elements, seasons, and parts of the body. In the circular movement, each element gives rise to the next (for example, winter gives rise to spring). The five-angled movement is a controlling one, in which each element restrains another.

medicine during the Song dynasty (960–1279 CE). To this day, differences between these theories are reflected in practitioners' approaches to diagnosis and treatment.

In Chinese thought, everything in the universe is composed of *yin* and *yang*—words that were first used to denote the dark and light side of a valley. Everything has *yin* and *yang* aspects, or complementary opposites—such as day and night, up and down, wet and dry. Every *yin* or *yang* category can itself also be subdivided—so that while the front of the body is *yin* relative to the back, which is *yang*, the abdomen is *yin* relative to the chest, which is *yang*.

The five elements theory associates constituents of the natural world—wood, fire, earth, metal, and water—with other fundamentals such as seasons, emotions, and parts of the body. Each element gives rise to the next in a perpetual fashion (see diagram above). For this reason, the system might be more accurately described as the five phases, representing the process of continual movement in life. The five elements have a central role in Chinese herbal medicine, especially in the grouping of tastes of herbs and parts of the body.

Diagnosis & Treatment

Instead of looking for causes of illness, Chinese practitioners seek patterns of disharmony, which are expressions of imbalance between *yin* and *yang*. Particular attention is given to reading the pulse and tongue, both of which are very important for an accurate diagnosis. Ill health results from a deficiency or excess of either *yin* or *yang*. A cold, for example, is not just the result of a virus (though this clearly is a cause), but a sign that the body is not adapting to external factors such as “wind-heat,” “wind-cold,” or “summer-heat.” A high temperature denotes too much *yang* and shivering

Fo ti
 (*Polygonum multiflorum*,
 p. 124), the oldest
 Chinese tonic herb, is
 used to prevent aging.

Dong quai
 (*Angelica sinensis*,
 p. 63) is taken by
 millions of Chinese
 women as a nourishing
 blood tonic.

Galangal (*Alpinia
 officinarum*, p. 61) is a
 warming herb used for
 abdominal pain.

Cinnamon (*Cinnamomum
 cassia*, p. 81) is a
 warming herb that
 helps the circulation.

Notopterygium root
 (*Notopterygium incisum*,
 p. 240) is used in China
 for colds, especially those
 accompanied by aching
 muscles and joints.

Ginkgo
 tablets

Ginkgo (*Ginkgo biloba*,
 p. 100) improves
 the memory and the
 circulation. Tablets,
 made from the leaves,
 are a bestselling herbal
 remedy in Europe.

Ginkgo
 seeds

Ginkgo
 leaves

Su xian hua
 (*Jasminum officinale*,
 see *J. grandiflorum*,
 p. 224) is an aromatic
 herb used to treat
 depression.